Corpus: prophecy and kingship (`/נבואה-ומלכות`)

▼ Contents

How the texts relate 1
Reading order 2
The two purposes (guidelines §1) 2
Files 2

Created 2026-10-21 (Round 3, run 3; `../curated-translation-candidates.md`, "Round 3 plan"). Two projects:

#	Folder	Text	Base text	Lines	Status
1	`1-נבואות-אשוריות/`	**The Assyrian prophecies**: SAA 9 1–11 (Parpola 1997), the oracles of the prophets of Ištar of Arbela and Mullissu to Esarhaddon, his mother and Assurbanipal (681–650 BCE)	ORACC `saao/saa09` (`../sources/ORACC/saao-saa09--Assyrian-Prophecies/`), CC BY-SA 3.0	652 tablet lines in 11 units	see `project.md`
2	`2--עצה-לנסיך/`	**Advice to a Prince** ("Fürstenspiegel"; eBL `L/2/5`): 55 lines in omen form on what befalls a king who wrongs Sippar, Nippur and Babylon	eBL (`../sources/eBL/Advice-to-a-Prince/`), ed. T. D. N. Mitto, translation B. R. Foster	55	see `project.md`

How the texts relate

Both texts are about the gods and the king, from two sides. The **prophecies** are the gods' word *to* the king through men and women in ecstatic speech, written down by scribes and kept in the palace archive of Nineveh: the god promises (fear not; I am with you; your enemies under your feet; your throne for long days), and the king is the god's child, nursed and carried. The **Advice** is the scholars' word *about* the king: if he wrongs justice, the scholars, the free cities, the gods will turn against him; it is a mirror for princes in the form of an omen list, copied at Nineveh (NA) and Nippur (NB). Together they are the two poles of the Torah's own debate about kingship: the

promise to the king (2 Sam 7; the royal psalms; Isa 41–44's "fear not" addressed to Israel), and the limits placed on him (the law of the king, Deut 17:14–20; Samuel's "rule of the king", 1 Sam 8:11–17; the prophet who confronts the king).

Reading order

1. SAA 9 1 (the ten oracles to Esarhaddon, c. 681–680, the civil war after Sennacherib's murder): the core of the genre.
2. SAA 9 2 (oracles about Babylon and the stabilization of the rule), SAA 9 3 (the "covenant of Aššur": the oracle as a treaty tablet, with a ritual meal), SAA 9 4–6 (fragments).
3. SAA 9 7, 9 (to Assurbanipal: the goddess as nurse; the goddess who roams the steppe for his life), 8 (Elam), 10–11 (fragments; a vision).
4. Advice to a Prince.

The two purposes (guidelines §1)

- **The Bible.** The "fear not" oracle (Gen 15:1, 26:24; Isa 41:10–14, 43:1–5, 44:2; Deut 31:6–8); the prophet as a professional in the king's service (Deut 18:9–22; 1 Kgs 22; Jer 28:9 "the prophet who prophesies peace"); the word of the god written and kept (Isa 8:16, 30:8; Jer 36); the god as mother and nurse (Num 11:12; Isa 46:3–4, 49:15, 66:12–13; Hos 11:3); the god's wings (Deut 32:11; Ps 91:4); the throne established (2 Sam 7:13); Assyria in the Bible (2 Kgs 18–19: the Rabshakeh's "let not Hezekiah make you trust"); the law of the king (Deut 17:14–20) and justice (Deut 16:18–20, 1:17).
- **The soul of the ancients.** How the Assyrians heard their gods: a mother who suckles, who stays awake at night, who roams the steppe and is worn out for her child; who is offended when her temple meal is neglected (SAA 9 3.5); who gives the king faith and promises him that the future will be like the past. The prophets' names are prayers ("Ištar, do not neglect (me)"); many were women; one (Bayâ) is called both "son" and "daughter". The Advice shows the scholars' fear of the king and their claim on him.

Files

- `renderings.md` – the shared renderings (binding; fixed before drafting).
- `prophecy_tools.py` – data, fill, verify, build, grep, lookup, shared (see its docstring and `../tools.md`).
- `translator-brief--prophecy.md` – the common translator brief.
- `parallels-index.md` – the projects' parallels by Bible verse (generated by `build_parallels_index.py` from the annotated **הקבלה** bullets).